USER MANUAL

TB Ambient

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Overview

Places a close-miked source at a distance outdoors using level, air absorption and ground material colour, without adding reverb, a delayed reflection or a tail.

What this plug-in solves

A close-miked recording dropped into an outdoor scene sounds too near and too clean, so it separates from the picture. Reaching for a hall or room reverb solves the wrong problem, because it builds an indoor space around a source that is supposed to be outside. Short reflections and delayed ground copies bring their own trouble: on footsteps, dialogue and impacts they produce static comb filtering that reads as a flanged, artificial edge. TB Ambient is intended for dialogue, footsteps, foley and impacts that need to belong to an exterior scene while staying dry.

What you can expect

- A source that reads as being at a distance rather than simply quieter
- Ground material heard as a broad tonal colour instead of a repeating notch
- No echo, reverb tail or modulation added behind the sound
- Bypass and Mix at zero return the original signal on the same sample

How it works

TB Ambient shapes one continuous signal path instead of adding a second, delayed one.

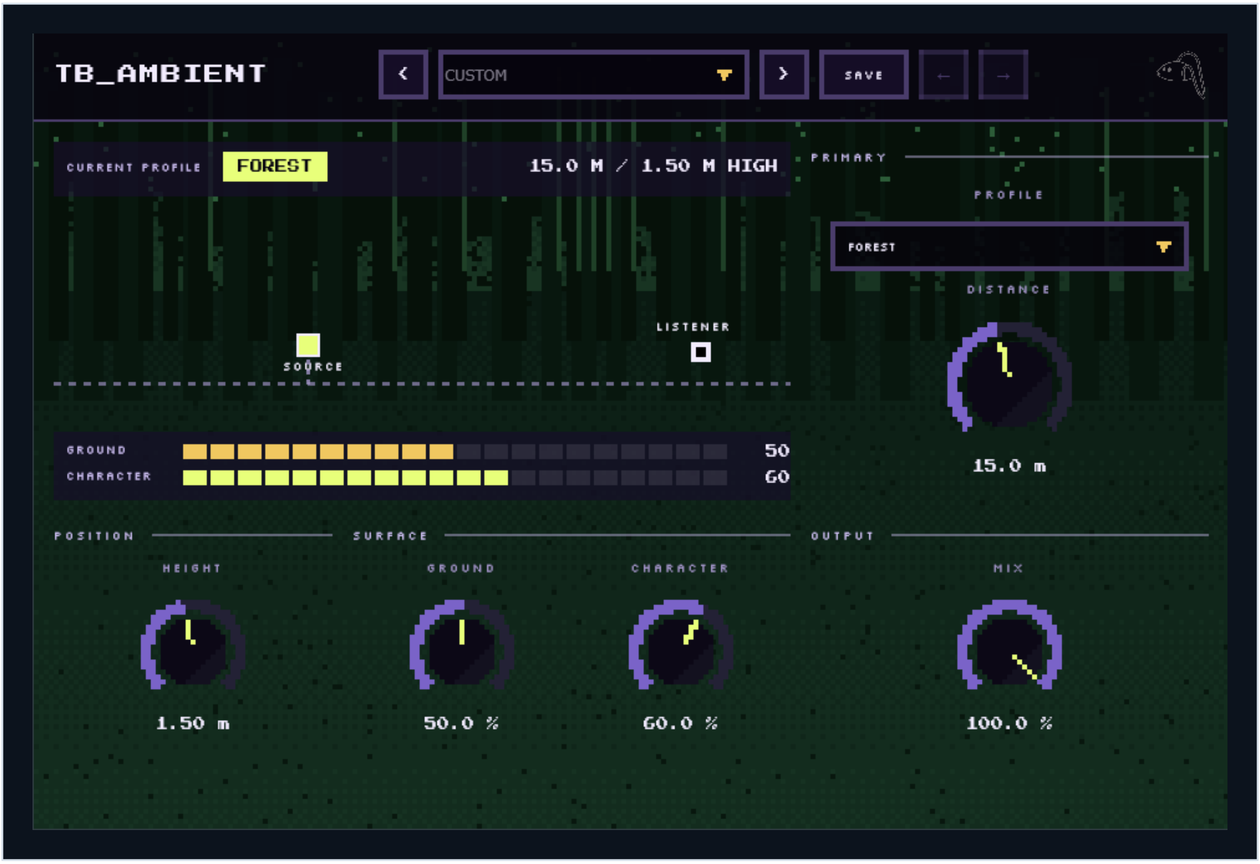
Distance is expressed through level, air absorption and ground colour together, which is what makes a source read as far away rather than merely quiet.

Because nothing is delayed, the processor adds no latency and no tail, and cannot produce the static comb filtering that a delayed ground copy creates on transient material.

Quick start

1. Insert the plug-in on the dry source and choose the Outdoor Profile that matches the scene.
2. Set Distance until the source sits at the right depth in the picture.
3. Set Height to match what is producing the sound rather than where the microphone was.
4. Adjust Ground for the surface, from soft ground through to hard.
5. Use Character to decide how strongly the profile is applied.
6. Leave Mix at 100 percent for a full placement, or lower it to keep more of the original tone.

Interface and key sections



This is a direct capture of the current plug-in interface. Use the visible labels to locate the areas and controls explained below.

Outdoor Profile

Eight profiles describe the surface and air a source is heard across: Open Field, Forest, Dry Asphalt, Damp Earth, Rocky Open, Coastal Air, Snowfield and Concrete Exterior. Each sets the ground material, how quickly high frequencies are lost with distance, and the overall tonal balance. Choose the profile that matches the picture first, then shape it with the remaining controls.

Distance

Distance is the main perspective control. Raising it lowers the level, removes high frequencies the way air does over a longer path, eases the proximity weight in the low end, and gradually focuses the image toward the centre. It changes tone and perspective together, which is why a distant setting sounds further away rather than merely quieter.

Height

Height is how far the source sits above the ground, from ankle level to well above head height. It changes the ground colour rather than the level: a footstep at 0.2 m meets the surface very differently from a voice at 1.5 m. Set it to match what is making the sound before fine-tuning Ground.

Ground

Ground moves the surface between soft and hard within the selected profile. Soft settings absorb more and darken the reflected colour; hard settings return more energy and keep it brighter. It is a broad material colour applied to the direct path, not a delayed copy, so it never introduces a repeating notch.

Character

Character sets how much of the selected profile's tonal signature is applied. Low values keep the source close to its original tone with only a hint of the outdoor scene; high values commit fully to the profile. Use it to match the strength of the effect to how far into the picture the source should sit.

Mix and the delayless path

Mix blends the processed signal with the original on the same sample. There is no latency to compensate, no tail to wait for, and no time smearing, so the plug-in can sit on dialogue and effects without disturbing sync. At Mix 0 percent the output is the input exactly.

Interface readout

The panel shows the current profile, the distance and height in metres, and segmented meters for Ground and Character. The placement view shows where the source sits relative to the listener and the ground line. It reflects only the six controls and does not imply reflections that the processor does not produce.

Controllable properties

The guide uses the names shown on the plug-in panel. Each explanation describes the audible result, a useful way to approach the control, and an important interaction to listen for.

Control	What it does and when to use it
Bypass	Returns the unprocessed input for an A/B check against the placed version. Match the loudness before judging; the switch is sample aligned, so there is no latency or tail to wait for.
Character	Sets how much of the selected profile's tonal signature is applied. Decide how far into the scene the source should commit.
Distance	Sets how far away the source reads, moving level, air absorption and stereo focus together. Set the depth first; it moves tone and level together.
Ground	Moves the surface between soft and hard within the selected profile, changing the reflected colour. Move between soft and hard until the surface reads correctly.
Height	Sets how high the source sits above the ground, which changes the ground colour rather than the level. Match the source, not the microphone.
Mix	Blends the placed signal with the original on the same sample. At 0 percent the output is the input exactly. Lower it only when some of the original tone must stay.
Outdoor Profile	Chooses the surface and air the source is heard across, which sets the ground material and how the tone changes with distance. Pick the profile from the picture, not from the sound alone.

Practical uses

Dialogue in an exterior scene

- Choose the profile that matches the location.
- Set Distance to the actor's real distance from camera rather than the closest flattering value.
- Keep Height near 1.5 m for a standing performer.
- Reduce Character if intelligibility starts to suffer.

Expected result: Speech belongs to the exterior without the boxed quality a room reverb would add, and stays readable.

Footsteps and foley

- Set Height low, around 0.2 m, because the sound is made at the ground.
- Match Ground to the surface underfoot.
- Keep Distance modest so the steps stay present.
- Compare against the unprocessed take at matched loudness.

Expected result: Steps sit on the surface and in the scene while keeping their transient definition.

Distant impacts and shouts

- Raise Distance well past the halfway point.
- Allow the high frequencies to fall away rather than adding brightness back.
- Use a profile with a hard surface if the location calls for one.
- Check the result against a nearby version of the same sound.

Expected result: The impact reads as genuinely far away instead of as a quiet near sound.

Common pitfalls

This is not a reverb. If a scene needs an audible tail or a room, that has to come from a separate processor. Place the source with this plug-in first, then add a reverb after it if the scene still needs a tail.

Distance cannot undo a close microphone's proximity character entirely; a source recorded very close still carries its own signature. Fix the proximity with EQ before reaching for more Distance, or the result only gets quieter.

Very high Character on already coloured material can stack tonal shaping; check against bypass at matched loudness. Lower Character until the profile is heard as placement rather than as extra tone shaping.

Ground and Height interact, because the surface colour depends on how high the source sits above it. Set Height for the source first and leave it there, then use Ground for the surface.